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by Rodrigo Munoz-Gonzalez, London, Routledge, 2024, 190 pp., (hardcover), ISBN: 9781032847559

Neerej Dev & Silpa Joy

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BOOK REVIEW

Young People, Media, and Nostalgia: An Ethnography of How Youth Imagine their Lives, by Rodrigo Munoz-Gonzalez, London, Routledge, 2024, 190 pp., (hardcover), ISBN: 9781032847559

Nostalgia, a longing for the past and its aesthetics, seems at odds with a generation raised on on-demand streams, TikTok trends, and relentless futurism. Yet, as Rodrigo Muñoz-González shows in Young People, Media, and Nostalgia: An Ethnography of How Youth Imagine their Lives, today's adolescents are captivated by fashions, sounds, and story-worlds from decades they never experienced. This unexpected attraction to retro culture is what he calls the 'nostalgia paradox'. The book anchors this paradox in an ethnography of Costa Rican teens who binge *Stranger Things*, belt out Queen classics, and restyle vintage denim as if the 1980s were their own lived past.

Muñoz-González opens with a vivid scene of Costa Rican teenagers donning 1980s garb for a *Stranger Things* themed contest, an entry point for defining nostalgia as 'a specific way of remembering the past' built on idealisation. Framing Latin American youth within globalised media circuits, he compares two field sites, a fee-paying school in Alajuela City and a public technical college in La Carpio; to show how classed positionalities shape what retro culture means. Chapter 1 therefore argues that Costa Rica's privatised education system and heavy reliance on imported entertainment, condition young people's encounters with the past. Chapter 2 then situates the study theoretically: drawing on Maurice Halbwachs, the author treats memory as inherently social, while nostalgia is a selective, affect-laden offshoot that polishes collective recollections into comforting myth (Keightley and Pickering 2012). The chapter introduces Pierre Nora's 'sites of memory' yet rejects Nora's clean split between history and memory in favour of their continual entanglement. Surveying scholarship, Muñoz-González contrasts a 'hermeneutics of suspicion' that brands nostalgia reactionary with a 'therapeutics of nostalgia' that sees recuperative potential (Niemeyer 2014), ultimately proposing an 'analytics of nostalgia' attentive to how feeling, meaning, and materiality together generate retro yearnings.

Chapter 3 examines how Costa Rican youth interpret nostalgic portrayals of the 1970s and 1980s in *Stranger Things* and *Bohemian Rhapsody* by describing these as 'spatiotemporal bridges' that link the present to an idealized past. Focusing on music, retro fashion, and vintage technologies, students view older eras as more relaxed, noting, for example, 'the absence of smartphones'. However, the author at times appears to overstate teenagers' agency, offering limited discussion of the broader cultural and economic structures shaping their interpretations. Chapter 4 spotlights students imagining localized versions of *Stranger Things* and *Bohemian Rhapsody*. Although students recognize that Costa Rica already possessed sizable urban centers, their imagined past still foregrounds a rustic, safer, freer, and more peaceful idyll stemming from a 'nostalgic social imaginary' (85) that romanticises a rural Arcadia even as it condemns present-day inequities.

Chapter 5 shows that St Mary's middle-class students relish the vintage aesthetics of the 1970s–80s; vinyl, fashion, 'simpler times', yet refuse to treat those decades as social blueprints. Their retro tastes spark intergenerational friction: elders valorise past political triumphs, while teens argue Costa Rica will progress only when their cohort leads. Muñoz-González deftly traces this tension but stops short of probing how rising evangelical currents

complicate students' broadly liberal stance. Chapter 6 shifts to Virilla Vocational in La Carpio, a district burdened by poverty, violence, and stigma so acute that employers recoil at its very name. Here, futures feel foreclosed; students wield 'material nostalgia' (123) to imagine a bygone era of community safety and economic security. Yet the longing is not monolithic: young women note that earlier decades also devalued female labour, exposing nostalgia's gendered fault lines. Across both sites, retro sensibilities function less as escapism than as diagnostic tools, on one hand St Mary's youth use them to critique cultural complacency and on the other Virilla's to navigate structural exclusion, revealing how class position mediates the affective labour of remembering (Wulf, Rieger, and Schmitt 2018).

Chapter 7 casts nostalgia as an argument with the present, splitting it into two class-laden strains. Among St Mary's middle-class teens, 'aesthetic nostalgia' prevails: they revere the craft of vintage music, film, and fashion yet disavow the era's social strictures, projecting instead a progressive future. By contrast, Virilla's working-class students cultivate 'material nostalgia', blaming their precarity on a 'selfish political class' (137) and idealising past decades marked by secure employment and communal safety. In both cases, U.S. and British media imports act as cultural touchstones, sharpening these distinct readings and enabling Costa Rican youth to simultaneously critique and affirm local realities. In his final chapter, Muñoz-González returns to the Greek roots *nostos* (homecoming) and *algos* (pain) to show nostalgia as an affect that reshapes history, identity, and memory. Class differences endure with St Mary students mourning lost style and Virilla students lost stability. Nostalgia therefore carries a 'dual potential' (154), illuminating the absent and energising the critique, yet just as easily with the power to sanitise the past and soothe present anxieties without redress.

Young People, Media, and Nostalgia is a valuable addition to the growing literature on youth media cultures and collective memory. By grounding his analysis in bilingual ethnography across two starkly different Costa Rican schools, Muñoz-González reveals how class inflects retro sensibilities and shows nostalgia to be both affective pulse and analytic lens. Crucially, he shifts debates beyond Euro-Atlantic settings, insisting that Latin American adolescents are not passive consumers of global pop-culture artefacts but active world-makers who mine the past to diagnose the present. Yet the study's celebratory tone occasionally outpaces its evidence. The absence of sustained engagement with political-economic constraints; how regional media markets, platform logics, or school funding structures delimit what students can imagine or enact often blunts claims about nostalgia's transformative promise (Brown et al. 2024). Likewise, fuller reflexivity about the author's own class and educational location, and a wider inclusion of youth outside formal schooling, would have sharpened the book's methodological edge. Even so, Muñoz-González offers a timely, empirically grounded provocation: that longing for decades never lived can expose structural absences – public safety, economic dignity, creative autonomy and galvanise new social imaginaries (Newman et al. 2020). For scholars of media, memory, and Latin American youth, his argument is both compelling and necessary as long as we keep asking who still gets left out of the nostalgic frame, and why.

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Neerej Dev
Doctoral Researcher, University of Wolverhampton, Wolverhampton, UK
Neerejdev@gmail.com http://orcid.org/0000-0003-3918-2406

Silpa Joy
Department of Functional and Applied English,
St Joseph's College Devagiri, Kozhikode, India
shilpajoyvayalil@gmail.com http://orcid.org/0009-0006-1885-0697

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